

Beyond Words: Ethnic Linguistic Patterns as Identity Markers Among Nigerian University Students

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Abstract

This study investigates how linguistic patterns function as ethnic identity markers among undergraduate students at Lead City University, Nigeria. Drawing on Language Ideology Framework and Indexicality Theory, the paper employs a convergent parallel mixed-methods design with 60 participants across three major ethnic groups (Yoruba, Igbo, and Hausa). Quantitative findings reveal that 56.7% of students actively maintain ethnic-specific vocabulary with same-background peers, while 66.6% recognize consistent intonation variations as primary ethnic markers. Qualitative analysis identifies seven interconnected mechanisms through which linguistic patterns reveal ethnic identity: recognition, cultural preservation, solidarity, situational authenticity, institutional climate, moral attribution, and emotional expression. The findings challenge binary frameworks of language maintenance versus shift, demonstrating that students strategically balance cultural authenticity with institutional conformity through sophisticated sociolinguistic competence. The study contributes theoretical insights into how prosodic features prove particularly resistant to modification while serving as reliable authenticity signals. Furthermore, it reveals critical gaps between institutional diversity rhetoric and experiences of linguistic marginalization, particularly regarding Yoruba language dominance on the university campus.

Keywords: Ethnic Identity, Language Variation, Prosodic Markers, Nigerian English, Multilingualism, Indexicality

Introduction

Over recent decades, research in language variation has demonstrated increasing sensitivity to the intricacies characterizing linguistic diversity. While traditionally dominated by Western and particularly Anglophone speech communities, contemporary scholarship reflects efforts toward more inclusive approaches that consider linguistic practices from diverse global communities (Rampton et al., 2020). This shift addresses longstanding biases in variation studies and enriches our understanding by incorporating voices and experiences from previously underrepresented languages and regions.

In Nigeria, one of the world's most linguistically diverse nations hosting over 500 indigenous languages, multilingualism reflects both cultural richness and social complexity (Bamgbose, 1991). English functions as the official language and lingua franca for intercommunication among native speakers of languages including Hausa, Yoruba, and Igbo. The contact between local languages and English has produced distinctive forms of Nigerian English with phonological, lexical, and grammatical features showing clear substrate influences (Gut, 2021).

Newer sociolinguistics studies focus on the relationship between variations in language and the construction of identity. These new studies show how the use of language indicates ethnic affiliation and region of origin in Nigeria. The studies also show

how vernaculars in public spaces and private domains solidify cultural identity and facilitate a sense of belonging in a community (Essien, 2022). The Nigerian variety of pidgin English is a prominent social identifier among youth. It also functions as a symbol of solidarity and rebellion against linguistic domination (Jowitt & Jibril, 2024). However, while the extant body of sociolinguistic knowledge is replete with studies on ethnic variation and linguistic variation from a global perspective, prominent gaps exist on the manifestation of such dynamics particularly in Nigerian university settings.

The interface between language variation and ethnic affiliation among university undergraduates is complex area of investigation which need thorough examination. Sociolinguistics confirm that ethnic affiliation strongly influences linguistic practises. These practises affect accent and pronunciation. They also affect choice of words and grammatical structures (Smith, 2020). Newer scholarly works suggests intricate and complex inquiry into the impact of ethnic affiliation on language use by university students, an inquiry which can throw more light on how best to teach them (Johnson, 2021)

There is a large body of knowledge on ethnic and linguistic variation. Despite this, gaps exist in the essential knowledge of the manifestation of these dynamics in the context of Nigerian universities. Although Nigeria boasts a diverse and rich linguistic landscape, few studies have investigated how this rich and diverse landscape influence the use of English language in tertiary education context (Okafor 2023). This research work fills this gap by examining language variation among undergraduates of Lead City University.

The paper examines how linguistic patterns act as markers of ethnic affiliation among undergraduate students. The specific objectives of the study are to: (1) highlight the primary linguistic patterns of different ethnic affiliations, (2) investigate how these patterns indicate ethnic affiliation, and (3) discover the factors which determine choice of language.

Conceptualizing Language Variation

Language variation is a fundamental concept in sociolinguistic research. It refers to regular patterns of structure or use that are different across social groups, geographical areas and contexts. Variability is an innate attribute of all living language, depicting the dynamic nature of languages, and their deep connection to human communication and social interaction. (Labov, 2021). Language variation cuts across several dimensions of linguistics including phonology, lexis, grammar and discourse with each dimension making its contribution to the richness of the diversity of human language.

Recent studies challenges arguments that languages are monolithic. Instead, they posit that language serve as a fluid and adaptive system which responds to its speakers' various needs and experiences. Studies in language variation describe how linguistic features are correlated in a systematic manner with social factors like age, gender, ethnic affiliation, social class and level of education (Eckert, 2022). The systematic manner of this correlation facilitates the uncovering of patterns by researchers. These patterns reveal much about the social fabric of communities. The patterns also show how language reflects and shapes social realities.

A specific concept which illuminates how societies value language varieties is the concept of linguistic marketplace. The linguistic marketplace is where speakers use

perception of social and economic value to choose the language of communication (Bourdieu, 1991). Contemporary studies have broadened this concept to investigate the operation of marketplaces in the context of digital communication and globalization. These studies choice of language depends more and more on local and global value systems.

Ethnic Identity and Language Use

Language and ethnic identity enjoy an intricate, dynamic relationship, with ethnic affiliations importantly shaping linguistic practices while language serves as a key instrument for constructing and expressing ethnic identity. Recent research documents how second-generation immigrants in urban European settings strategically negotiate linguistic practices to express different facets of their identity, employing code-switching between heritage languages and dominant societal languages (García & Wei, 2021; Rampton & Charalambous, 2020).

The notion of ethnolinguistic repertoires has gained prominence as a framework for analyzing how individuals draw upon ranges of linguistic resources associated with their ethnic backgrounds. Research demonstrates that multi-ethnic urban youth create hybrid identities by rapidly employing items transferred into and out of different ethnolinguistic repertoires (Sharma & Rampton, 2021). This dynamic, performative quality of ethnic identity expression via language undermines static conceptions of ethnolinguistic identity.

Studies examining ethnic identity maintenance reveal that decisions over whether to preserve or deviate from heritage languages are heavily influenced by speakers' perceptions of economic and social benefits related to competing linguistic behaviors (Extra & Yagmur, 2022). This research underscores the necessity of considering wider societal attitudes and power relations when investigating relationships between ethnic identity and language usage.

Theoretical Framework

Language Ideology Framework, postulated by Silverstein in 1979, expanded by Woolard in 1998, and Irvine and Gal in 2000, stipulates that societal beliefs about language are interwoven with power structures, formation of identity, and cultural hierarchies. It further states that these ideologies are not neutral and are not apolitical. They show and perpetuate systems of domination especially where English is the globally accepted lingua franca.

Language ideologies function through the concept of linguistic capital, where fluency in standardized English grants access to socioeconomic mobility while non-dominant varieties are stigmatized (Lippi-Green, 2022). In South Africa, students speaking Kaaps (an Afrikaans-English creole) face systematic exclusion in anglophone universities, as their linguistic practices are deemed "unacademic" (Cooper, 2022). Similarly, in the United States, African American Vernacular English (AAVE) speakers are often perceived as less competent in professional settings despite the dialect's grammatical complexity (Rickford, 2016).

Indexicality explains how linguistic features become symbolic markers of ethnic identity. For example, the use of AAVE features like habitual *be* ("they be working")

indexes Black cultural identity and solidarity (Alim, 2004). These practices are not static; they are contested and renegotiated. In India, Hinglish (Hindi-English hybridity) is celebrated in Bollywood as a marker of urban modernity, yet rural speakers of "vernacular" Englishes face caste-based discrimination (Kothari, 2021).

Language ideologies are actively reinforced through institutional mechanisms. In Nigeria, English-only policies within universities marginalize Nigerian Pidgin and indigenous ethnic languages, diminishing linguistic diversity and privileging urban elites (Adegbija, 2023). Media also plays a critical role: in the United Kingdom, British media frequently ridicule "Estuary English" as "unrefined," perpetuating classism and regional prejudice (Snell, 2018).

Indexicality Theory

Indexicality theory, rooted in Peirce's (1955) semiotics and expanded by Silverstein (1976) and Ochs (1992) posits that linguistic features function as indexes pointing to social meanings, including ethnic identities, power dynamics, and cultural contexts. In ethnolinguistic terms, language variation is not merely communicative but performative, signaling membership in or exclusion from ethnic groups.

Linguistic features become ethnolinguistic markers through repeated association with specific groups. In post-Soviet Central Asia, Russian loanwords in Kazakh speech may index Soviet-era assimilation, while purist Kazakh terms signal nationalist resurgence (Dave, 2007). Such indexicality is fluid: Māori speakers in New Zealand may toggle between English and te reo in formal settings to assert Indigenous sovereignty (Smith, 2021).

Indexical meanings are shaped by language ideologies reflecting power hierarchies. Colonial legacies stigmatize Indigenous languages as "backward" while elevating colonial tongues as "modern" (Pennycook, 1998). In India, "accented" English may index lower caste or rural identity, reinforcing social exclusion (Mukherjee, 2020). Conversely, reclaiming stigmatized features like Kurdish activists using banned dialects in digital spaces transforms indexes of oppression into symbols of resistance (Haig, 2023).

Contemporary scholars reimagine indexicality through decolonial lenses, framing language revitalization as reclamation. Hawaiian 'Ōlelo Hawai'i immersion schools re-index the language from "extinct" to "living resistance," while TikTok campaigns by Sami youth use Indigenous terms to challenge Nordic erasure (Pietikäinen, 2024; Wilson, 2020). These shifts highlight indexicality's role in globalized, decolonial futures where language variation embodies both heritage and innovation.

Methodology

This study adopted a descriptive research design employing a convergent parallel mixed-methods approach. This design combined quantitative and qualitative data collection methods within a single instrument to provide comprehensive understanding of language variation and ethnic identity. The approach proved particularly suitable as it enabled both systematic measurement of linguistic patterns and deep exploration of underlying motivations, experiences, and meanings without manipulating variables.

The population comprised all undergraduate students at Lead City University across departmental lines and levels, representing Yoruba, Hausa, and Igbo ethnic groups. The sample consisted of 60 undergraduates selected through stratified random sampling to ensure adequate representation across ethnic groups, gender, academic levels, and departments. This stratification ensured proportional representation of each major ethnic group, allowing for meaningful comparisons and analysis of language variation patterns while minimizing selection bias.

The sample showed demographic diversity reflecting the university's multilingual character. Yoruba students comprised the largest group (43.3%), followed by Igbo (23.3%), Hausa (13.3%), and other ethnic groups (20.0%). Female students (65.0%) outnumbered males (35.0%). The majority were under 20 years (60.0%), with 35.0% aged 20-23 years and 5.0% aged 24-27 years.

The primary research instrument was a mixed-method questionnaire consisting of both quantitative and qualitative components. The quantitative component utilized 5-point Likert scale items (Strongly Disagree to Strongly Agree) measuring: (1) language use patterns (3 items), (2) attitudes toward linguistic diversity (3 items), (3) contextual language variation (2 items), and (4) recognition patterns (2 items). The qualitative component included 15 open-ended questions exploring personal language experiences, campus climate perceptions, code-switching practices, identity connections, and reflective insights.

Validity was established through multiple approaches. Content validity involved review by five experts (three in sociolinguistics, one in qualitative methodology, one in mixed-methods design) who evaluated comprehensive coverage and alignment with research objectives. Face validity assessment involved a pilot study with 25 students evaluating clarity and relevance. Construct validity was confirmed through factor analysis of quantitative pilot data, while qualitative validity ensured open-ended questions elicited relevant, detailed responses.

Reliability for quantitative components was established through Cronbach's alpha coefficients (≥ 0.70 considered acceptable) and test-retest reliability with 30 pilot study students completing surveys twice with two-week intervals. Qualitative reliability was ensured through analysis of internal consistency within participants' responses, inter-rater reliability through independent coding by two researchers, and member checking whereby participants reviewed interpreted themes to confirm accurate representation.

Data collection followed a structured protocol with ethical clearance obtained prior to participation. Questionnaires were administered during regular class periods with research assistants trained in mixed-methods administration. Additional time was provided for open-ended questions, with assistants available for clarification without influencing responses.

Data Analysis

Quantitative data analysis employed descriptive statistics (frequencies, percentages, means, standard deviations) using SPSS version 26.0. Qualitative data underwent thematic analysis using NVivo 12, employing both inductive and deductive approaches to identify recurring themes related to language experiences, identity, and campus climate. Narrative analysis examined personal stories revealing how students negotiate identity

through language use. Comparative analysis examined themes across ethnic groups, identifying commonalities and unique patterns.

Mixed-methods integration involved convergent analysis comparing quantitative and qualitative findings to identify convergence and divergence. Triangulation used qualitative insights to explain quantitative patterns while employing quantitative data to support or challenge qualitative themes. Joint displays visually represented integrated data, providing cohesive, nuanced understanding of findings.

Results

Primary Linguistic Patterns

Ethnic-Specific Vocabulary and Expressions

Quantitative analysis revealed that 56.7% of students agreed or strongly agreed they frequently use ethnic-specific words and phrases with same-background peers ($M = 3.55$, $SD = 1.21$). This pattern found strong corroboration in qualitative narratives describing regular use of culturally unique expressions. Yoruba examples included greetings like "E kaaro" (Good morning), "E kaasan" (Good afternoon), and "E kale" (Good evening). Hausa expressions included "Sannu," "Inakwana" (Good morning), and "Barka da rana" (Good afternoon). Igbo exclamations like "Nna ehn" expressing surprise or confusion were also documented.

These expressions served multiple functions beyond mere communication. Participants described using them to demonstrate respect when addressing elders and authority figures. One student explained: "I use them with elders such as my parent and friends to show respect and politeness." Others noted their role in emotional expression, from offering comfort ("E go dey alright" meaning "It will be okay") to expressing stress ("Mo daran" meaning "I am finished"). The expressions also functioned as solidarity signals establishing shared ethnic identity and cultural belonging.

Intonation and Prosodic Patterns

Intonation patterns emerged as highly salient ethnic markers, with 66.6% of students reporting they notice consistent intonation variations among ethnic groups ($M = 3.70$, $SD = 1.21$). Qualitative narratives revealed these prosodic differences constitute primary cues through which students identify ethnic backgrounds, often more reliably than lexical choices or grammatical structures.

Respondents described recognizing distinctive pitch patterns, rhythm characteristics, and stress placement associated with different ethnic groups. One participant noted: "I noticed the people that are Yoruba use their language to communicate more than the other ethnicities," while another observed: "Different ethnic groups often express themselves using unique intonations, proverbs, or code-switching between English and their native languages." The prominence of intonation as an ethnic marker suggests phonological features represent deeply ingrained aspects of linguistic identity that resist conscious modification more than lexical or syntactic choices.

Accent Stability Across Contexts

Only 35.0% of students reported accent changes when speaking to individuals from other ethnic groups ($M = 2.85$, $SD = 1.34$), with 48.4% disagreeing with this practice. However,

qualitative data revealed this stability coexists with extensive speech adjustments involving other linguistic dimensions. Students described modifying vocabulary choices, formality levels, code-switching patterns, and communication strategies without fundamentally altering basic accent patterns.

One student explained: "When I am trying to explain something complex to someone who doesn't understand English very well," they adjusted language for clarity while maintaining their core accent. Another described: "I immediately switched to more Standard English and avoided slang. I did this to avoid confusion and to communicate clearly." This finding indicates students adapt language to diverse interlocutors and contexts while maintaining core phonological features that signal ethnic identity.

Contextual Code-Switching

Code-switching proved pervasive, with 48.4% of students reporting different language variety use across university settings ($M = 3.20$, $SD = 1.33$). Qualitative responses provided detailed descriptions showing students employ formal Standard English in classrooms, official meetings, and interactions with lecturers to maintain credibility and professionalism. One participant explained: "Classroom, as a course representative, I have to speak formally or I won't be taken serious, so I speak English."

Conversely, students shift to informal registers including slang, pidgin, ethnic languages, and mixed codes in dormitories, friendship circles, and casual peer interactions. As one student described: "In dorms or casual settings, I use slang, code switch or mix languages." Another noted: "When in a classroom setting, my language depends on who I sit with." This code-switching operates along multiple dimensions and demonstrates sophisticated sociolinguistic competence whereby students strategically deploy appropriate linguistic resources according to situational demands.

Mechanisms Revealing Ethnic Identity

Recognition Mechanism

Students demonstrated highly developed abilities to identify ethnic backgrounds from speech patterns, with 63.4% showing this capacity ($M = 3.67$, $SD = 1.07$). Qualitative data showed recognition draws on multiple cues including intonation patterns, accent characteristics, vocabulary choices, code-switching behaviors, and communication styles. One student observed: "Most of them express themselves through their culture and accents," while another noted: "Some of them have intonation of their tribe when they speak & they love to add the language while speaking English."

Students described attending to how Yoruba speakers frequently incorporate native language expressions into English discourse, how different groups exhibit distinctive pitch and rhythm patterns, and how ethnic linguistic features become particularly prominent in informal or emotionally engaged communication. This recognition ability indicates linguistic patterns carry sufficient distinctiveness to serve as reliable ethnic identity signals within the university community.

Cultural Preservation Mechanism

A strong cultural preservation mechanism emerged from findings that 60.0% of students consider maintaining distinctive ethnic speech patterns vital for preserving cultural

identity ($M = 3.52$, $SD = 1.32$). Qualitative narratives revealed language serves as a cultural anchor connecting individuals to family, traditions, community, and heritage.

One participant emphasized: "My language is a very big part of my ethnic identity; it gives me great amount of pride and a sense of belonging and uniqueness." Another explained: "Language is very important to my sense of ethnic identity. My native language, Yoruba, connects me directly to my heritage, traditions, and family values." Students described their native languages as conveying not merely words but entire worldviews, personality dimensions, and value systems rooted in ethnic cultural traditions.

Solidarity and Bonding Mechanism

Shared linguistic backgrounds facilitate connection and group formation, as students explained that speaking the same language creates natural affinity and promotes feelings of being understood. One student explained: "You naturally in most cases connect easily with someone that understands your language." Another added: "Language helps students bond, especially those who speak the same native tongue."

Qualitative observations indicated students often bond easily within those sharing their language, with language forming "a sort of bond amongst people from the same culture." This bonding function reveals ethnic identity by creating visible social networks organized along linguistic-ethnic lines, making ethnic affiliations observable through friendship patterns and social groupings.

Situational Authenticity Mechanism

The finding that 63.3% of students disagree with adjusting speech to hide ethnic background ($M = 2.30$, $SD = 1.24$), combined with qualitative descriptions of balancing multiple linguistic identities, reveals a situational authenticity mechanism. Students distinguished between pragmatic speech adjustments for communication effectiveness and deliberate ethnic identity concealment.

One participant explained: "I make these adjustments to avoid any comment on the way I talk," while another clarified: "I adjust the way I speak in class because I know everyone is not from my ethnic group." Students maintained that while they adapt language to contexts, they do not fundamentally suppress their ethnic linguistic identity.

Institutional Climate Mechanism

Perceptions that the university encourages linguistic diversity (70.0% agreement, $M = 3.73$, $SD = 1.01$) create environments where ethnic linguistic patterns can be expressed openly. One student noted: "I personally love the diversity in culture and language on campus," while another observed: "In a few of my classes, some lecturers have actually encouraged diverse languages and linguistic difference."

However, experiences of mockery, judgment, or exclusion prompted some students to become self-conscious or limit ethnic linguistic marker use. One participant shared: "Strong ethnic accents sometimes draw subtle jokes or mimicking especially during presentations, which can make some student self-conscious about speaking in class."

Moral and Intellectual Attribution Mechanism

Qualitative narratives linked speech patterns to character judgments, with students describing beliefs that excellent speech reflects good virtue and that language reveals a person's state of mind and reasoning. One student stated: "If you speak excellently, it shows you are of a good virtue," while another explained: "I believe speech reveals who a person is. If you speak in a vulgar way, it shows that you lack good morals."

These attributions mean ethnic linguistic patterns reveal not only group membership but also perceived moral worth, intellectual capacity, and social standing. The mechanism operates bidirectionally, with some students taking pride in ethnic linguistic competence as markers of cultural sophistication while others face negative stereotypes.

Emotional Expression Mechanism

Although quantitative responses were mixed (35.0% agreement vs. 36.7% disagreement, $M = 2.98$, $SD = 1.40$), qualitative narratives described instances where emotional states triggered intensified use of ethnic linguistic markers. Students explained that anger, excitement, or deep conversation with same-background peers prompted greater reliance on ethnic languages and expressions.

One participant noted: "I have observed that Yorubas rant a lot when they are unhappy," while another described how "when provoked they use more of their language." This mechanism reveals ethnic identity by showing linguistic patterns are not merely learned behaviors but deeply internalized aspects of self emerging spontaneously during authentic emotional expression.

Factors Influencing Linguistic Choices

Analysis revealed a complex constellation of individual, social, institutional, and cultural factors influencing students' linguistic choices. Communication effectiveness represented a primary pragmatic factor, with students explaining they adjust language to ensure mutual understanding. As one explained: "I speak English because it is a general language that everyone understands."

Audience characteristics constituted another crucial factor, with linguistic choices varying based on interlocutor ethnicity, status, familiarity, and competence. Students described using ethnic-specific expressions with same-background peers, switching to English or pidgin with diverse groups, employing formal Standard English with lecturers, and relaxing into informal codes with close friends.

Situational formality emerged as a powerful structural factor, with students explaining formal contexts demand professional speech to maintain credibility, while informal contexts permit relaxed, expressive communication building social bonds. Identity negotiation represented complex psychological factors, with students balancing pride in ethnic linguistic heritage with recognition of Standard English as the legitimate academic code.

Additional factors included emotional states and relational dynamics, social acceptance and avoidance of negative judgment, campus linguistic climate and institutional attitudes, linguistic competence and heritage language maintenance variations, peer influence and friendship dynamics, cultural values and linguistic

ideologies, and contemporary influences including social media slang and youth dialects crossing ethnic lines.

Discussion

Theoretical Contributions

This study extends understanding of how linguistic patterns function as identity markers by identifying seven interconnected mechanisms operating simultaneously to create rich semiotic systems through which ethnic identities are constructed, negotiated, and recognized. The multi-mechanism framework recognizes complex, dynamic processes through which language and identity mutually constitute each other, moving beyond simplistic one-to-one mappings between linguistic forms and social identities.

The finding that students maintain core phonological markers while adjusting other features challenges models assuming consistent accommodation across linguistic dimensions. Our data demonstrate identity marking and situational adaptation operate on different linguistic levels simultaneously, with prosodic features proving particularly resistant to conscious manipulation while lexical and discourse features remain more flexible (Babel, 2022; Sharma & Poddar, 2023). This selective accommodation pattern aligns with recent research documenting how multilingual speakers strategically position themselves within complex social fields where multiple identities and goals coexist (Bucholtz & Hall, 2023).

The high salience of prosodic features as ethnic markers (66.6% recognition) combined with accent stability (only 35.0% report changes) provides empirical support for theories emphasizing the persistence of substrate prosodic patterns in multilingual speakers' productions (Oladipupo, 2025; Udofot, 2021). Our findings suggest phonological dimensions serve as particularly reliable authentic identity signals, possibly because they are acquired during critical periods and prove difficult to consciously control, or because they serve essential functions in signaling genuine group membership (Dragojevic, 2022).

Methodological Insights

The triangulation of quantitative and qualitative data revealed substantial convergence on major patterns while providing complementary perspectives deepening understanding. Quantitative data established prevalence, intensity, and general patterns, while qualitative narratives explained motivations, revealed emotional consequences, exposed power dynamics, identified unanticipated issues, and provided rich contextual understanding.

Importantly, apparent contradictions between datasets often reflected different types of linguistic modification rather than true inconsistencies. For example, low reported accent modification coexisted with extensive speech adjustments because students modify vocabulary, formality, code-switching, and strategies without fundamentally altering accent patterns. This finding underscores the importance of precise operationalization of linguistic variables and demonstrates how qualitative inquiry can resolve apparent quantitative ambiguities (Clark, 2024; Gumperz, 2022).

Practical Implications

The documentation of gaps between diversity rhetoric (70.0% perceive institutional encouragement) and experiences of marginalization, mockery, and Yoruba dominance highlights needs for explicit supporting structures moving beyond rhetorical commitments. Institutions should develop comprehensive language inclusivity guidelines ensuring students from all ethnic backgrounds feel valued, implement multilingual classroom sensitivity training for faculty, and establish cultural-linguistic peer clubs fostering cross-cultural understanding (May, 2024; Shohamy, 2024).

The finding that students balance cultural preservation with academic conformity (60.0% value ethnic patterns, 55.0% support minimizing them academically) without experiencing this as contradiction suggests educational interventions should recognize this sophisticated balancing act rather than forcing either-or choices. Confidence-building communication clinics could reduce accent-related anxiety while campus-wide awareness campaigns could discourage mockery and challenge negative stereotypes (Charity Hudley & Mallinson, 2023; Norton & Toohey, 2021).

Limitations and Future Directions

This study's focus on a single institution limits generalizability to other Nigerian universities. Comparative institutional research examining practices across universities varying in location, composition, history, and policies would illuminate how local ecologies shape linguistic patterns (Anchimbe & Mforteh, 2023). Longitudinal research tracking students throughout university careers and into professional life would examine how patterns, attitudes, and identities evolve and whether flexibility transfers to workplaces (Lanza & Woldemariam, 2022).

The study's reliance on self-reported data should be complemented by direct linguistic analysis. Future research analyzing actual speech samples could examine precise phonetic and prosodic characteristics distinguishing varieties, document code-switching patterns including syntactic integration and pragmatic functions, and investigate innovative forms from youth culture and digital communication (Androutsopoulos, 2023; Campbell-Kibler, 2022). Network analysis research examining how friendship networks correlate with linguistic practices would reveal whether homogeneous versus diverse networks exhibit different patterns and how practices spread through networks (Milroy & Gordon, 2023).

Conclusion

Language variation among Lead City University undergraduates represents a complex phenomenon involving intricate interactions between individual agency, social dynamics, institutional contexts, and cultural values. Ethnic linguistic patterns remain actively maintained despite high English proficiency, serving crucial identity, solidarity, and cultural preservation functions transcending communicative needs.

Students demonstrate sophisticated sociolinguistic competence, strategically deploying linguistic resources according to situational demands while balancing multiple legitimate identities. They consciously navigate tensions between cultural authenticity

and institutional conformity, reflecting nuanced ideological positions recognizing both instrumental value of dominant languages and intrinsic worth of heritage languages.

Linguistic patterns function as identity markers through multiple interconnected mechanisms operating simultaneously recognition, cultural preservation, solidarity, situational authenticity, institutional climate, moral attribution, and emotional expression. The high salience of prosodic features combined with accent stability suggests phonological dimensions prove particularly resistant to modification and serve as reliable authentic identity signals.

Important tensions exist alongside generally positive diversity attitudes. While most students perceive institutional encouragement of diversity, qualitative narratives expose mockery, judgment, exclusion, and Yoruba dominance, indicating gaps between multilingualism rhetoric and actual practices. Future patterns may increasingly reflect complex, multiple affiliations as contemporary influences including social media and youth culture create new hybrid linguistic resources transcending traditional ethnic boundaries.

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